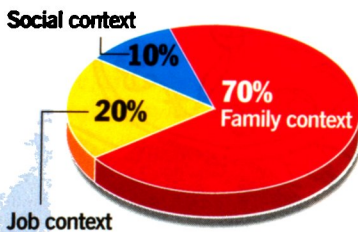


Fathers on a guilt trip

- 25% fathers accord highest priority to their fathering role and responsibility.
- 50% feel sad when they can't keep promises or spend sufficient time with their children.
- 25% fathers feel frustrated when they fail to provide for the child's needs, or act as a role model.
- 62% feel guilty for not being present during illnesses or emergencies.
- 70% feel unhappy when their parenting ideals cannot be converted into action.
- 80% face difficulties in fulfilling their children's physical and psychological needs.
- 50% find it hard to create a conducive environment for children.
- 40% realise their children's need for freedom but find it hard to relinquish control.

Source : Sriram et al, *Application of Action Theory to Fathering Ideals ...* 2002.

what stops dads from getting involved



- 38% due to lack of time, work pressure, family or role demands.
- 30% due to lack of skills, interest, unsuitable temperament.
- 7% due to perceived gender norms.
- 21% due to the ability to easily cop out of duties at home.

Source : Sriram et al, *Indian Fathers as Carers and Nurturers*, 2005



bly one of those Sunday fathers for his 11-year-old twins, Parthiv and Paroma: "I'm lucky if I can say 'hi' to them on weekdays." But the son has started asking for more time these days, says his wife Madhu: "As a solution, Harsh sometimes takes Parthiv to office." Meantime, Neotia continues to be plagued by remorse: "There are some men who can take care of everything and still be home for dinner. I never seem to manage it."

The sense of guilt pushes some men to overcompensate children with expensive gifts. Chakrawarti, for example, recently bought a toy-scooter scooter for Rs 5,000 on his three-year-old daughter Anaya's birthday ("She knows how to get me to say yes to everything"). Deb narrates the case of a father whose plastic parts business with Tata Motors left him with no time in hand. To compensate, he would 'bribe' his teenage son with a car, unlimited pocket money, even membership access for playing golf at his club. The son did not misbehave or lose interest in studies. "He just lost interest in his parents," says Deb, "He was totally detached from anything at home." The father made serious efforts to build bridges, but it was too late to reinvent the wheel. Psychiatrist N. Rangarajan of Chennai is not surprised. "It's a common mechanism for fathers to compensate for their absence from home," he says, "but very often it harms the way a child grows up

RAJEEV RAMACHANDRA, 40,
FOUNDER, MISTRAL SOFTWARE, BANGALORE
A hard-earned moment of togetherness with wife Priya, an engineer who prefers to look after their two sons, Sambhav and Sankalp.

“I'm very close to my two sons. I cuddle them lots whenever I'm with them.”

and forms relationships as an adult.”

Much more alarming is the way new research quantifies the effects of this physical or emotional absenteeism. In March, British scientists analysing thousands of babies born around the turn of the millennium claimed that children with absentee fathers score lower on tests of empathy, reasoning and brain development. They behave more aggressively, are more likely to have trouble forming relationships and are more reluctant to take responsibility for misbehaviour. In 2002, the US National Center for Policy Analysis had concluded such children were up to three times more likely to engage in a criminal activity, and a 1993 Harvard study had showed that the amount of time a father spent with his children could affect their ability at math and sports.

The bottom line is, fathers are in conflict. Sriram calls them “transient, confused fathers” caught between changing worlds: “They were brought

70-80% FATHERS DO NOT TURN UP FOR PARENT-TEACHER MEETINGS IN SCHOOLS